

European Chemicals

Air Liquide SA

Rating

Outperform

Price Target

 **AI.FP**

202.00 EUR (189.00 OLD)



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Air Liquide 1H26 - Speed bump, but remain Outperform

We identified the potential for [Air Liquide's 1H26 results to be a speed bump](#), and the market has taken issue with a tricky print but limited impact on longer-term fundamentals, in our view ([Quick Take: Air Liquide 1H26 - Complicated, but not thesis-changing](#)). After perhaps a slight expectations reset, we believe the road gets easier from here. The backlog remains at record levels, we remain optimistic on further growth acceleration, and the 5 October CMD remains a catalyst. We remain Outperform, and see 1H26 weakness as an entry point.

We actually raise our comparable growth forecasts for 2H26 by 40 bps, upgrading expectations in Electronics and Industrial Merchant. Although we maintain our Large Industries conservatism, we follow management guidance of sustainable 8-9% growth in Electronics and forecast a sequential 50bps improvement in Industrial Merchant based on easing helium supply constraints and stable qoq pricing. Overall, we forecast FY26 comparable growth of +3.2% in line with various consensus sources (FY26 estimates of +3.0% for Vara, and +3.4% for VA). This implies 2H growth is sequentially 90bps above 1H, but only +20bps vs. 2Q, and we believe this is consistent with the ever conservative Air Liquide definition of "slightly higher than the first half", particularly in the context of [their previous 1Q=2Q guide](#). We continue to forecast higher sequential margin improvement in 2H26, at +120bps yoy, also based on the easing helium headwind.

There may be a helium overhang for a few more quarters, however. Our understanding is that pre-Iran Air Liquide was overweight Qatari helium, implying they sourced over 1/3 of their product from Qatar ([link](#)), and this is higher than peers. Although production has restarted, which can then be trucked to other ports by road, helium volumes are not likely to reach prior levels until Qatar can freely export LNG through the Strait of Hormuz. We see Air Liquide's helium headwind as temporary, but normalcy may be some quarters away and until then helium is likely to dampen the margin improvement story. And we see Air Liquide's helium impact as being greater than their US peers, hence our current preference for Linde and Air Products.

Investment Implications

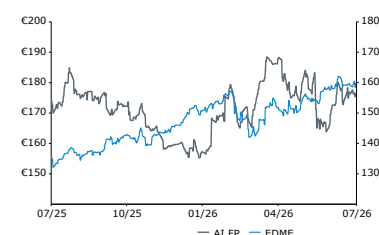
We rate Air Liquide Outperform with a raised Price Target of €202. We raise our 26 & 27 EPS estimates by c.+3% and c.+5%, respectively. We roll our valuation framework from a FY26 P/E to a NTM P/E incorporating the average of our FY26 and FY27 EPS. On a multiple of 28x NTM P/E (unchanged), our price target is raised to €202 from €189.

Adjusted EPS	F25A	F26E	F27E	Financials	F25A	F26E	F27E	CAGR	Valuation Metrics	25A	26E	27E
AI.FP (EUR)	6.70	6.96	7.44	EBIT (M)	5,582	6,154	6,797	--	Reported P/E (x)	29.0	29.3	25.0
OLD	--	6.76	7.06	Dividend/Share	3.70	3.96	4.24	--				

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

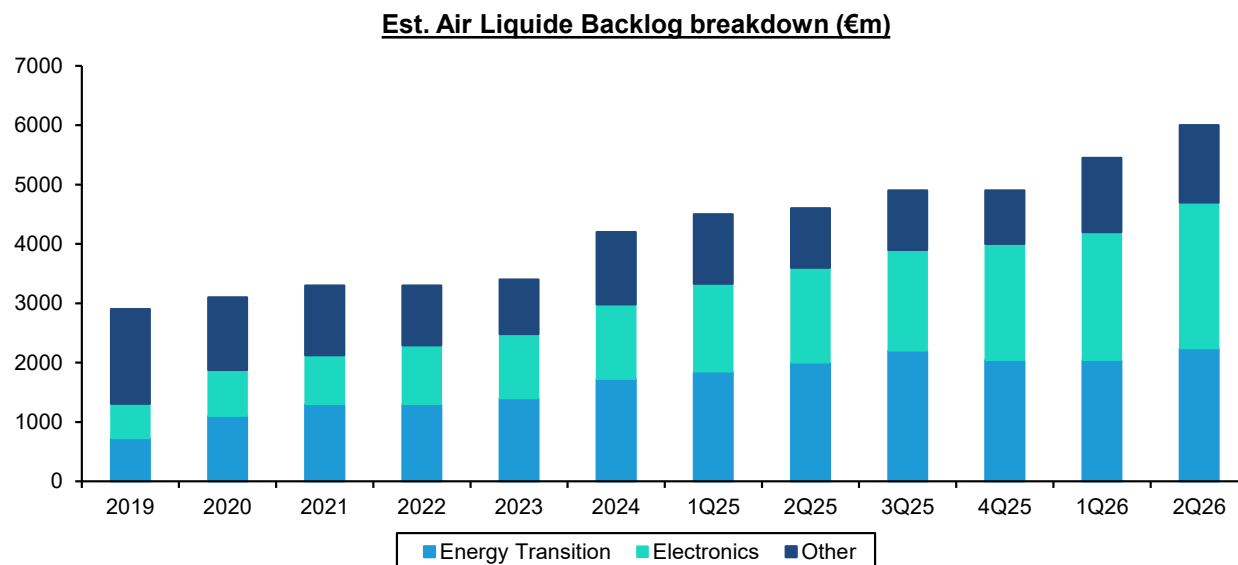
Close Date	27 Jul 2026			
AI.FP Close Price (EUR)	177.18			
Price Target (EUR)	202.00			
Upside/(Downside)	14%			
52-Week Range	182.26/140.78			
EDME	--			
FYE	Dec			
Div Yield	1.9%			
Market Cap (EUR) (M)	110,198			
EV (EUR) (M)	126,141			
Performance	YTD	1M	6M	12M
Absolute (%)	18.5	(0.1)	21.1	10.2
EDME (%)				
Relative (%)				
Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.				

Price Performance, 1YR



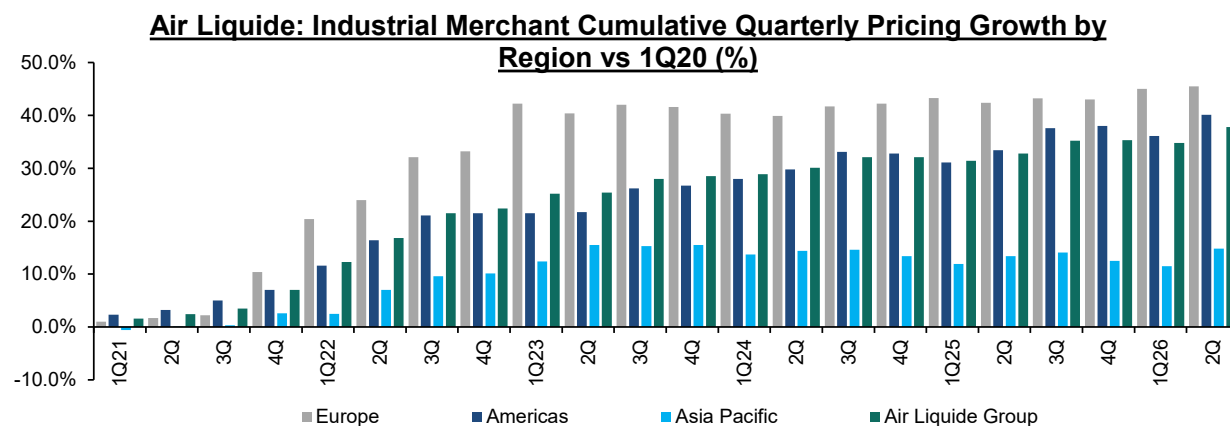
DETAILS

EXHIBIT 1: **The backlog reached a record €6.0bn in 2Q26, with €500m more projects sequentially**



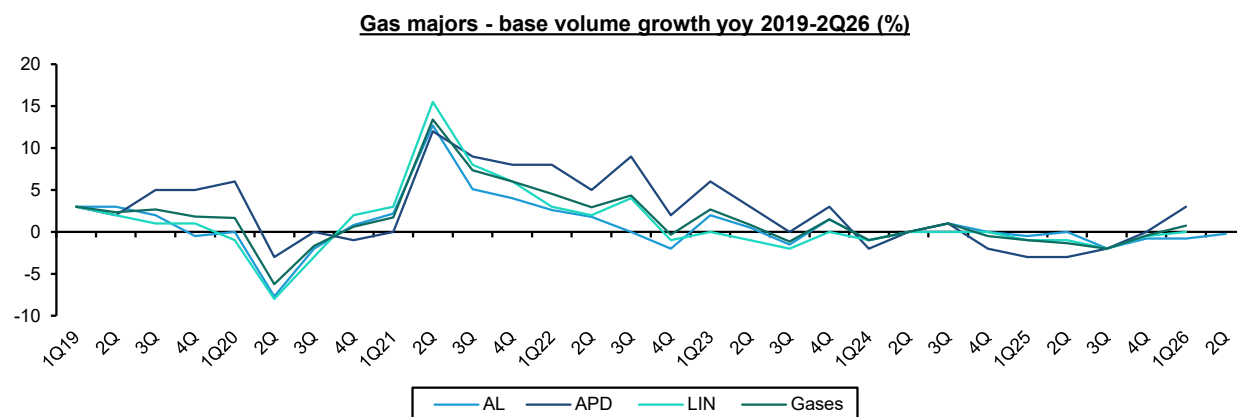
Source: Company information, Bernstein estimates and analysis

EXHIBIT 2: **Air Liquide IM cumulative price by region vs 2020 (%)**



Europe Includes Africa & the Middle East as of 4Q24

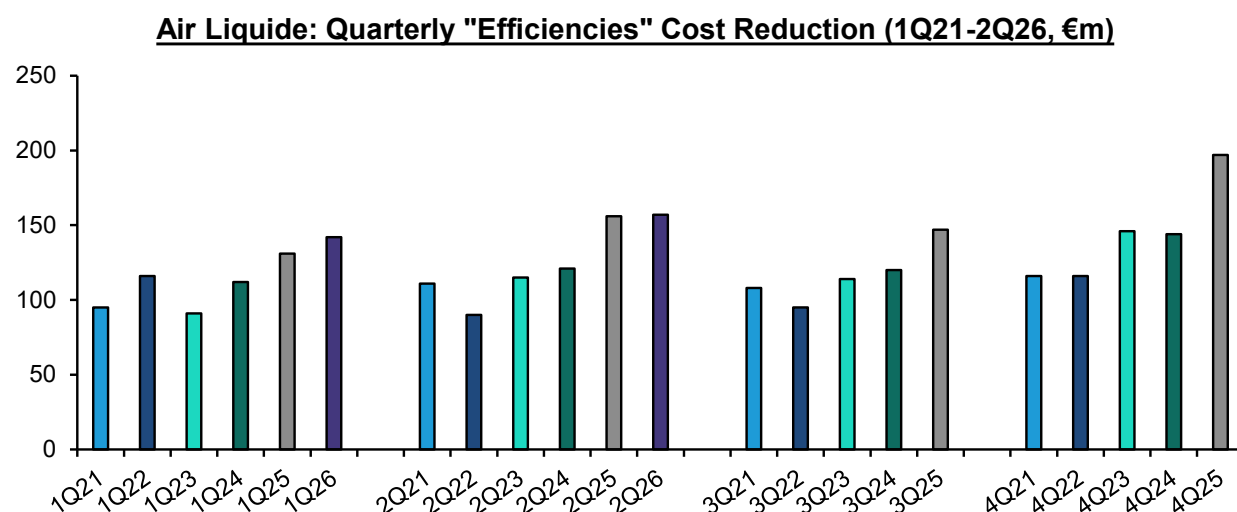
Source: Bernstein analysis and estimates, company data

EXHIBIT 3: **We believe Air Liquide base volumes are yet to inflect, not helped by helium**

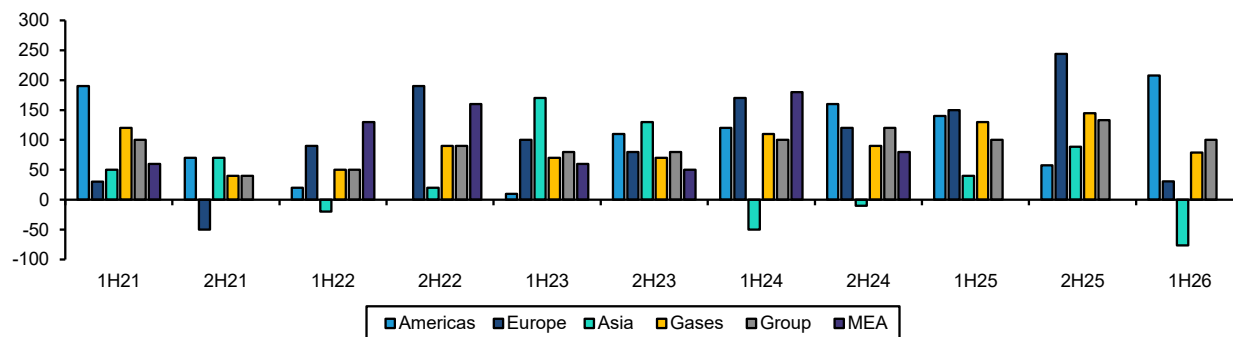
Calendar quarters

APD and Linde have not published their 2QFY26 figures yet

Source: Company information, Bernstein estimates and analysis

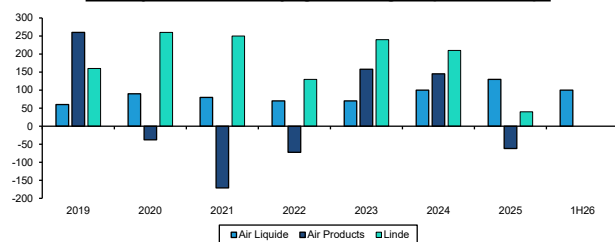
EXHIBIT 4: **Efficiency benefits by Air Liquide have been stepping up, although yoy growth rates slowed in 2Q26**

Source: Company information, Bernstein analysis

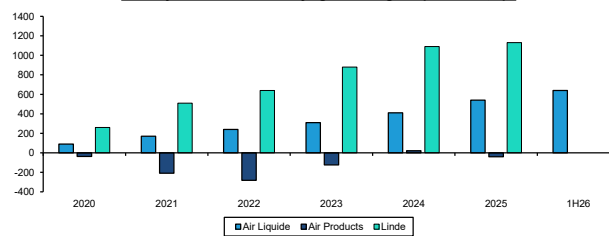
EXHIBIT 5: Air Liquide's margins continue to make progress, even if Asia was down in 1H26**Air Liquide - Underlying EBIT margin advance by region 2021-2026 (bps)**

Europe and MEA have been amalgamated from 1H25; Europe's margin has been restated for internal transfers to Industrial Merchants

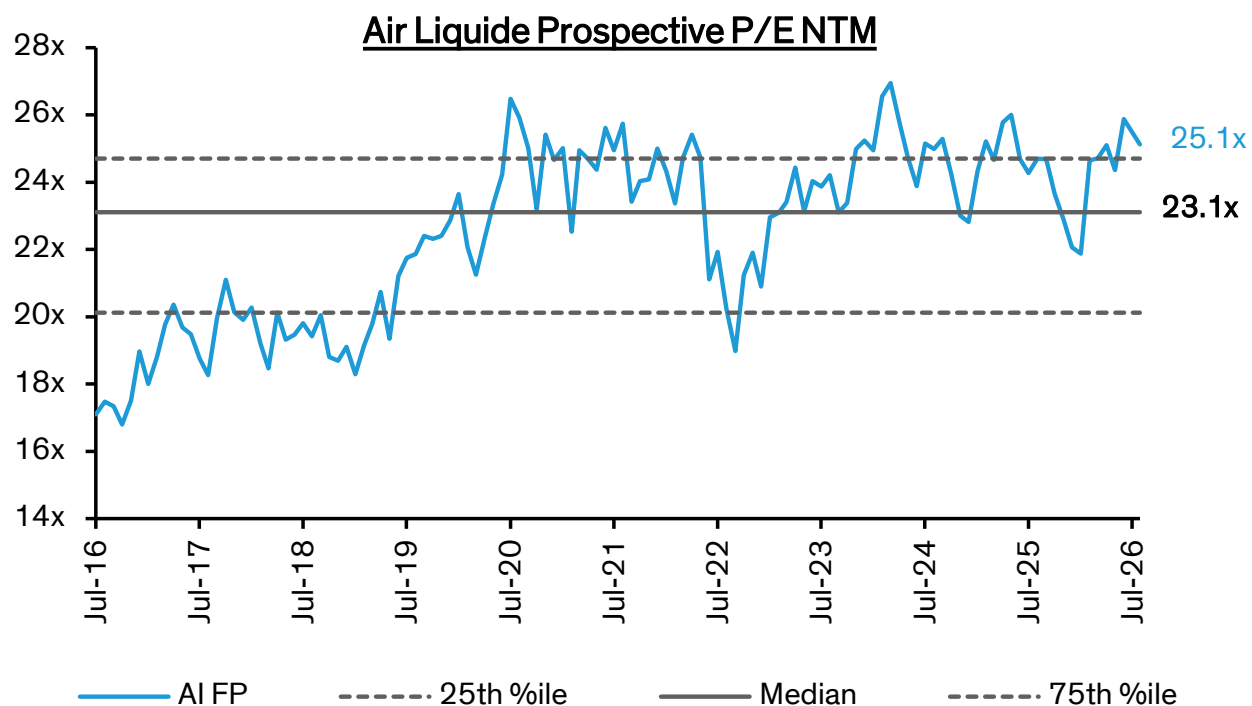
Source: Bernstein analysis, company data

EXHIBIT 6: Air Liquide continues to make progress improving their margins**Gas majors annual underlying EBIT margin improvement, bps**

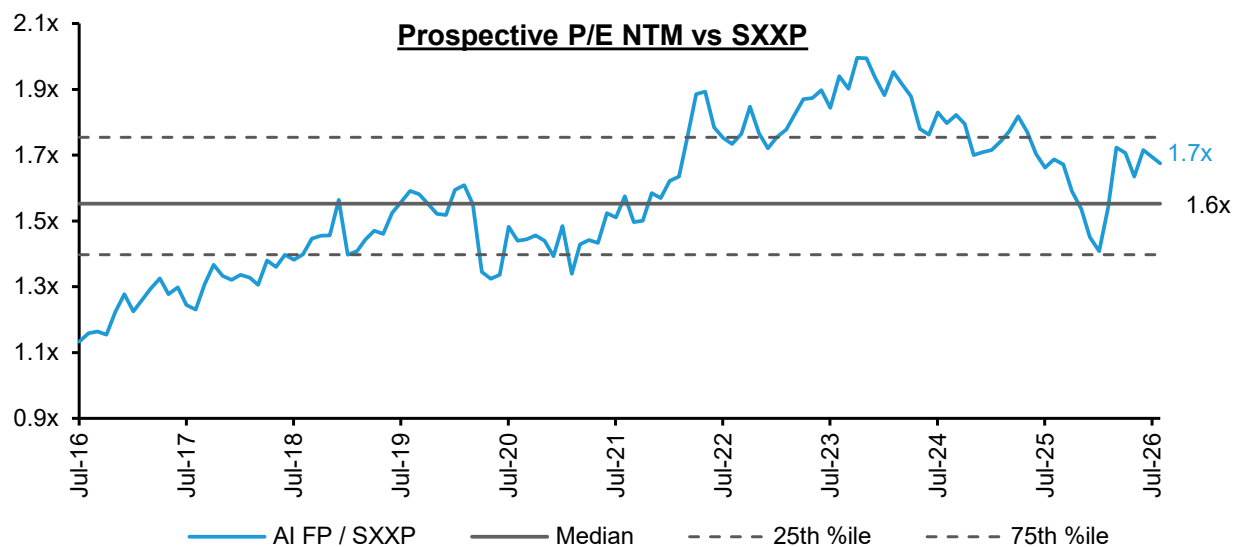
Source: Company data, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 7: They have made significant improvements vs. 2020**Gas majors cumulative underlying EBIT margin improvement, bps**

Source: Company data, Bernstein analysis and estimates

EXHIBIT 8: **Air Liquide's valuation has returned to close to historical averages**

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 9: **Air Liquide's premium to the Eurostoxx 600 is also close to averages**

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

KEY INDUSTRIAL GASES RESEARCH

INDUSTRIAL GASES

- 22 Jul 2026 - [The Future of European Chemicals: The carbon tax conundrum - updated for last week's ETS changes](#)
- 15 Jul 2026 - [Chemicals: Specialty or Commodity, with potentially tough times in between](#)
- 26 May 2026 - [The Long View: Chemicals - Analysing the lasting impact on upstream chemicals of the Iran war](#)
- 07 May 2026 - [The Bernstein Industrial Gases Primer: How the industry structure can support long-term outperformance](#)
- 21 Apr 2026 - [Chemicals 1Q26 Preview: Poker Faces](#)
- 20 Apr 2026 - [Chemicals: Positioning for an Iran-related cycle and upgrading Arkema to Market-Perform](#)
- 16 Mar 2026 - [The Future of European Chemicals: The carbon tax conundrum](#)
- 13 Mar 2026 - [Global Industrial Gases & Semis: Assessing the helium impact](#)
- 23 Feb 2026 - [The Long View: The Industrial Gas space opportunity - rocket fuel for growth](#)
- 12 Feb 2026 - [Chemicals: There is still share price upside if we see a cyclical recovery - a scenario analysis](#)
- 08 Jan 2026 - [Chemicals Outlook 2026: A slow start, but there could be considerable upside potential. Downgrading Solvay to Market-Perform.](#)
- 01 Dec 2025 - [The Long View: How Industrial Gases revenues can compound at the magic 5% through 2030](#)
- 13 Aug 2025 - [European Chemicals: War and Peace II - Refreshing our Ukraine war scenarios](#)
- 10 Jul 2025 - [Reflections on the European Chemicals Action Plan: First aid, but no cure](#)
- 27 May 2025 - [Chemicals: Amongst the tariff turmoil](#)
- 9 April 2025 - [Industrial Gas Majors - It's a big world, after all but gases don't travel so "Hold Tough" and Buy](#)

AIR LIQUIDE

- 29 Apr 2026 - [Air Liquide 1Q26: Who is the guidance for?](#)
- 23 Feb 2026 - [Air Liquide 2H25: More growth and more margin improvement](#)
- 28 Jan 2026 - [Air Liquide: Best European Idea First Quarter 2026 – Improving growth that isn't priced in. Outperform](#)
- 03 Dec 2025 - [Quick Take: A day with Air Liquide at the SDC Premium Review](#)
- 29 Oct 2025 - [Air Liquide 3Q25: Typically solid, and potentially the growth trough](#)
- 25 Sep 2025 - [Air Liquide at the Bernstein European Industrials Forum: Reassuringly Consistent](#)
- 22 Aug 2025 - [Quick Take: Air Liquide acquires DIG Airgas - a high price, but a worthy purchase](#)
- 30 Jul 2025 - [Air Liquide 1H25: "This is just the beginning"](#)
- 28 Jul 2025 - [Air Liquide: Marginal Gains](#)
- 29 May 2025 - [Quick Take: Air Liquide Americas CEO at the SDC](#)

- 24 April 2025 - [Air Liquide - Steady as she goes](#)
- 21 February 2025 - [Air Liquide - Pushing the margin again....](#)
- 14 February 2025 - [Air Liquide- We see the FY24 EBIT margin +110bp and scope for c.500bp more from there](#)

AIR PRODUCTS

- 17 Jul 2026 - [Air Products: Sustainable above-consensus EPS growth, even including NEOM](#)
- 30 Jun 2026 - [Quick Take: Air Products cancels Darrow & 3QFY26 update](#)
- 27 May 2026 - [Bernstein SDC: Air Products Takeaways](#)
- 01 May 2026 - [Air Products 2QFY26: This may not be the last guidance raise of the year](#)
- 02 Feb 2026 - [Air Products 1QFY26: Turnaround in Motion](#)
- 08 Dec 2025 - [Air Products gives a mega-project update: the industrial gas energy transition story is not over yet](#)
- 26 Nov 2025 - [Air Products 4QFY25: Making progress as focus moves to Darrow](#)
- 31 Jul 2025 - [Quick Take: APD 3Q25 - A first beat for new management](#)
- 1 May 2025 - [Quick Take: Air Products 2Q25 — a sobering update on the job in hand](#)
- 25 February 2025 - [Air Products - rapid megaproject rationalisation shows a renewed focus on shareholder value](#)
- 6 February 2025 - [Air Products - No surprises from the 1Q25 release](#)
- 4 February 2025 - [New leadership at Air Products to support density, discipline, de-risking and ... dependability](#)
- 31 January 2025 - [Air Products - Upgrading to outperform Density, discipline, de-risking...dependability?](#)

LINDE

- 05 May 2026 - [Linde 1Q26: Earnings Aristocrat, and potentially improving core growth](#)
- 19 Feb 2026 - [Linde 4Q25: Earnings Aristocrat, and well positioned for all macro scenarios](#)
- 3 Nov 2025 - [Linde 3Q25: Earnings Aristocrat, but also an underappreciated growth story](#)
- 31 Oct 2025 - [Quick Take: Linde 3Q25 - 27 Adj. EPS beats in a row, but a guidance narrow rather than raise](#)
- 4 Aug 2025 - [Linde 2Q25: Earnings Aristocrat](#)
- 1 Aug 2025 - [Quick Take: Linde 2Q25 - 26 EPS beats in a row, and what's 3 cents between friends?](#)
- 22 July 2025 - [Linde: Earnings aristocrat 2Q25 - we see the 26th quarter of consecutive EPS beats](#)
- 4 Jun 2025 - [Linde: A day with the CEO at the SDC - "The value is visible" ... in the field, networks, density, benchmarking, ownership, 45Q...](#)
- 29 Apr 2025 - [Linde: Earnings Aristocrat? 1Q25 - we see the 25th quarter of consecutive EPS beat and underlying sequential growth](#)
- 6 February 2025 - [Linde - As expected the 24th beat, 1Q and FY25 guidance light and a share reaction like with 3Q24...](#)
- 4 February 2025 - [Linde - We see the 24th consecutive EPS beat, and qoq growth but the macro drag on guidance, but...](#)

APPENDIX - FINANCIAL FORECASTS

EXHIBIT 10: Air Liquide financial summary

Air Liquide (EURmn)	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	2026E	2027E	2028E	2029E	2030E
P&L																
Net sales	21,920	20,485	23,335	29,934	27,608	27,057	26,940	6,786	7,042	7,239	7,325	28,392	29,883	31,344	32,892	34,497
Gas & Services	21,040	19,656	22,267	28,573	26,360	25,809	26,085	6,596	6,812	7,019	7,088	27,515	28,984	30,427	31,956	33,542
E&C / E&T (from 2025)	328	250	387	474	390	412	855	190	230	220	237	877	899	917	935	954
Global Markets & Technology	552	579	681	887	858	836										
Other																
Total growth	4.3%	-6.5%	13.9%	28.3%	-7.8%	-2.0%	-0.4%	-3.4%	5.2%	9.7%	10.7%	5.4%	5.2%	4.9%	4.9%	4.9%
COGS	-8,154	-7,198	-9,389	-13,813	-11,147	-10,008	-9,651		-4,953		-4,980	-9,933	-9,812	-9,947	-10,111	-10,282
Gross profit	13,766	13,288	13,946	16,121	16,461	17,050	17,289		8,875		9,585	18,514	20,071	21,397	22,781	24,214
margin	62.8%	64.9%	59.8%	53.9%	59.6%	63.0%	64.2%		64.2%		65.8%	65.2%	67.2%	68.3%	69.3%	70.2%
Operating expenses	-8,022	-7,500	-7,764	-9,364	-9,407	-9,599	-9,447		-4,780		-5,092	-9,872	-10,463	-10,959	-11,484	-12,029
Operating income recurring before D&A	5,932	5,928	6,333	7,328	7,550	7,897	8,145		4,219		4,642	8,915	9,881	10,711	11,570	12,458
EBITDA	5,744	5,788	6,182	6,757	7,054	7,451	7,842		4,096		4,492	8,643	9,609	10,438	11,297	12,186
Depreciation and amortisation expense	-2,138	-2,138	-2,173	-2,466	-2,482	-2,505	-2,564		-1,325		-1,436	-2,761	-3,085	-3,219	-3,361	-3,513
Operating income recurring (OIR)	3,794	3,790	4,160	4,862	5,068	5,392	5,582		2,893		3,206	6,154	6,797	7,492	8,209	8,946
margin	17.3%	18.5%	17.83%	16.24%	18.36%	19.93%	20.72%		20.9%		22.0%	21.7%	22.7%	23.9%	25.0%	25.9%
EBIT	3,606	3,650	4,010	4,291	4,572	4,946	5,279		2,771		3,056	5,881	6,524	7,220	7,936	8,673
Financial income	-467	-444	-403	-385	-411	-419	-404		-209		-205	-445	-578	-622	-667	-712
Profit before tax	3,139	3,206	3,607	3,906	4,160	4,527	4,875		2,562		2,850	5,412	5,946	6,597	7,269	7,961
Income taxes	-802	-678	-915	-1,002	-972	-1,087	-1,231		-675		-751	-1,426	-1,501	-1,665	-1,835	-2,009
Profit for the period	2,338	2,528	2,692	2,904	3,188	3,440	3,644		1,887		2,100	3,986	4,445	4,932	5,434	5,952
Minorities	96	93	120	145	110	134	127		64		69	134	141	147	155	162
Net profit (group share)	2,242	2,435	2,572	2,759	3,078	3,306	3,518		1,823		2,030	3,853	4,305	4,784	5,279	5,789
margin	10.2%	11.9%	11.0%	9.2%	11.1%	12.2%	13.1%		13.2%		13.9%	13.6%	14.4%	15.3%	16.1%	16.8%
Basic EPS (€)	4.31	4.68	4.94	5.28	5.90	5.74	6.10		2.86		3.19	6.05	7.10	7.89	8.70	9.54
Adjusted EPS (€)	4.55	4.58	5.11	6.07	6.39	6.15	6.70		3.17		3.42	6.96	7.44	8.22	9.03	9.86
Adjusted EPS growth %		0.6%	11.5%	18.8%	5.3%	-3.7%	8.8%		-1.3%		-2.4%	4.0%	6.8%	10.5%	9.8%	9.2%
Balance Sheet																
Cash & cash equivalents	1,026	1,882	2,331	1,953	1,720	1,919	4,342		2,153		4,772	4,772	6,801	9,150	11,715	14,503
Intangibles	15,498	14,485	15,445	16,399	15,826	16,669	15,386		18,220		18,220	18,220	18,220	18,220	18,220	18,220
Plant, property and equipment	21,118	20,003	22,532	23,647	23,652	25,539	24,910		26,538		27,141	27,141	28,319	29,572	30,903	32,312
Inventories and trade receivables	4,009	3,612	4,279	4,996	5,021	5,186	4,995		6,804		5,856	5,856	6,015	6,230	6,462	6,703
Other	2,016	1,995	2,197	2,524	2,113	2,555	2,281		2,562		2,616	2,616	2,593	2,644	2,699	2,755
Total Assets	43,667	41,977	46,783	49,518	48,332	51,868	51,913		56,278		58,605	58,605	61,949	65,816	69,999	74,492
Trade payables	2,567	2,438	3,333	3,783	3,311	3,319	3,004		3,274		3,479	3,479	3,486	3,657	3,837	4,025
Provisions	2,521	2,418	2,292	1,991	2,005	2,026	2,029		2,065		2,065	2,065	2,065	2,065	2,065	2,065
Borrowings	13,399	12,401	12,695	12,173	10,846	11,075	12,378		15,982		15,982	15,982	17,582	19,182	20,781	22,381
Other	5,855	5,677	6,427	6,984	7,084	7,826	7,477		7,666		7,801	7,801	7,871	8,005	8,148	8,296
Total liabilities	24,342	22,973	24,784	24,946	23,289	24,246	24,966		29,015		29,356	29,356	31,032	32,937	34,860	36,794
Total shareholders equity	19,324	19,005	21,999	24,572	25,043	27,622	26,947		27,263		29,250	29,250	30,917	32,879	35,139	37,698
Total equity and liabilities	43,667	41,977	46,783	49,518	48,332	51,868	51,913		56,278		58,605	58,605	61,949	65,816	69,999	74,492
Net debt	12,373	10,609	10,448	10,261	9,221	9,159	8,416		13,921		11,302	11,302	10,873	10,123	9,157	7,970
Net debt/OIR before D&A	2.1x	1.8x	1.6x	1.4x	1.2x	1.2x	1.0x		1.7x		1.3x	1.1x	1.1x	0.9x	0.8x	0.6x
ROIC (ex. intangibles)	14.8%	16.1%	16.4%	17.6%	18.3%	18.5%	18.4%		18.6%		18.7%	19.4%	19.8%	20.8%	21.8%	22.7%
ROCE (company defined)	8.6%	8.6%	9.3%	10.3%	10.6%	10.7%	11.2%				11.1%	11.6%	12.5%	13.4%	14.2%	
Cash Flow Statement																
Cash and equivalents at start of period	1,549	896	1,719	2,139	1,761	1,404	1,303		3,678		1,805	3,678	4,424	6,409	8,714	11,236
Cash flows from operating activities (CFO)	4,712	5,206	5,571	5,810	6,263	6,322	6,518		1,954		4,701	6,656	7,330	8,043	8,678	9,340
Cash flows used in investing activities (CFI)	-2,585	-1,955	-3,352	-3,242	-3,079	-3,583	-3,751		-4,709		-2,039	-6,748	-4,263	-4,472	-4,693	-4,921
o/w purchases of PP&E and intangible asset	-2,636	-2,630	-2,917	-3,273	-3,393	-3,525	-3,843		-1,828		-2,039	-3,867	-4,263	-4,472	-4,693	-4,921
Cash flows from (used in) financing activities	-2,780	-2,428	-1,816	-2,781	-3,480	-2,808	-345		925		-43	882	-1,038	-1,222	-1,420	-1,631
Net increase (decrease) in cash flow	-653	824	404	-213	-296	-69	2,423		-1,829		2,619	790	2,029	2,349	2,566	2,787
FX and other	1	-1	17	-165	-62	-32	-47		-44		0	-44	-44	-44	-44	-44
Cash and equivalents at the end of the pe	896	1,719	2,139	1,761	1,404	1,303	3,678		1,805		4,424	4,424	6,409	8,714	11,236	13,980
Free cash flow to equity (Bernstein)	265	1,154	1,816	1,186	948	1,885	4,122		3,355		2,553	5,882	4,332	4,803	5,184	5,583
Free cash flow yield	0.6%	2.5%	3.9%	1.7%	1.1%	2.2%	4.5%		3.2%		2.4%	5.8%	4.3%	4.8%	5.2%	5.5%
Dividend yield	3.0%	3.0%	3.2%	2.2%	1.9%	2.2%	2.4%					2.4%	2.6%	2.7%	2.9%	3.1%
Dividend	2.45	2.49	2.63	2.95	3.20	3.30	3.70				3.96	4.24	4.53	4.85	5.19	
Dividend payout ratio	53.8%	54.4%	51.5%	48.6%	50.1%	53.7%	55.3%				56.9%	57.0%	55.1%	53.7%	52.6%	
Revenue Growth Drivers																
YoY Revenue Growth %	4.3%	-6.5%	13.9%	28.3%	-7.8%	-2.0%	-0.4%	-3.4%	5.2%	9.7%	10.7%	5.4%	5.2%	4.9%	4.9%	4.9%
Comparable Growth %	3.2%	-1.3%	8.2%	8.2%	3.7%	2.6%	1.8%	1.9%	3.4%	3.6%	3.8%	3.2%	4.7%	4.9%	4.9%	4.9%
Portfolio	0.5%	-1.4%	1.2%	15.6%	-1.4%	-0.9%	0.0%	1.6%	1.7%	1.7%	1.7%	1.7%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
Currencies	2.1%	-2.0%	-1.6%	-1.6%	-4.2%	-2.2%	-3.2%	-5.8%	-1.3%	1.8%	1.1%	-1.1%	0.5%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
Natural Gas	-1.4%	-1.8%	6.1%	6.1%	-5.9%	-1.5%	1.1%	-1.0%	1.3%	2.5%	4.0%	1.7%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
Gases Comparable Growth %	3.5%	-1.2%	7.3%	6.1%	4.2%	2.7%	1.9%	1.9%	3.3%	3.7%	3.9%	3.2%	4.8%	5.0%	5.0%	5.0%

Source: Air Liquide, Bernstein analysis and estimates

BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

Ticker	Rating	Cur	27 Jul 2026	Price Target	TTM Rel. Perf.	Adjusted EPS				Reported P/E (x)		
			Closing Price			Cur	2025A	2026E	2027E	2025A	2026E	2027E
Al.FP (Air Liquide)	O	EUR	177.18	202.00	10.2%	EUR	6.70	6.96	7.44	29.0	29.3	25.0
OLD				189.00				6.76	7.06			
EDME			--									

PRICE TARGET CHANGE / ESTIMATE CHANGE IN BOLD

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

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VALUATION METHODOLOGY**Air Liquide SA**

We value the gas majors on prospective P/E and regard c.28x NTM as appropriate for Air Liquide. This is at a premium to the top end of AL's historical range reflecting the re-rating of the gas majors as the industry has consolidated and seen improved discipline, alongside the attractions of their resilient mix (with a high proportion of protected income) but also long-term growth potential. It also (rightly in our view) represents a modest discount to its closest peer, Linde plc given its stronger earnings potential and discipline. Hence, our PT of €202.

RISKS**Air Liquide SA**

Downside: With a new CEO since June 2022 communicating a strong focus on performance any setbacks will likely have an exaggerated impact on the share price (PT impact -€10). Given its high exposure to North America IM sales (c.70% of regional sales) a deepening recession scenario would likely weigh heavily on the share price (PT impact -€10); If IM pricing falters (PT impact -€5); If the project backlog falters again (PT impact -€5), especially if uncertainties in the clean hydrogen story see a lack of new signatures here (PT impact c.-€10).

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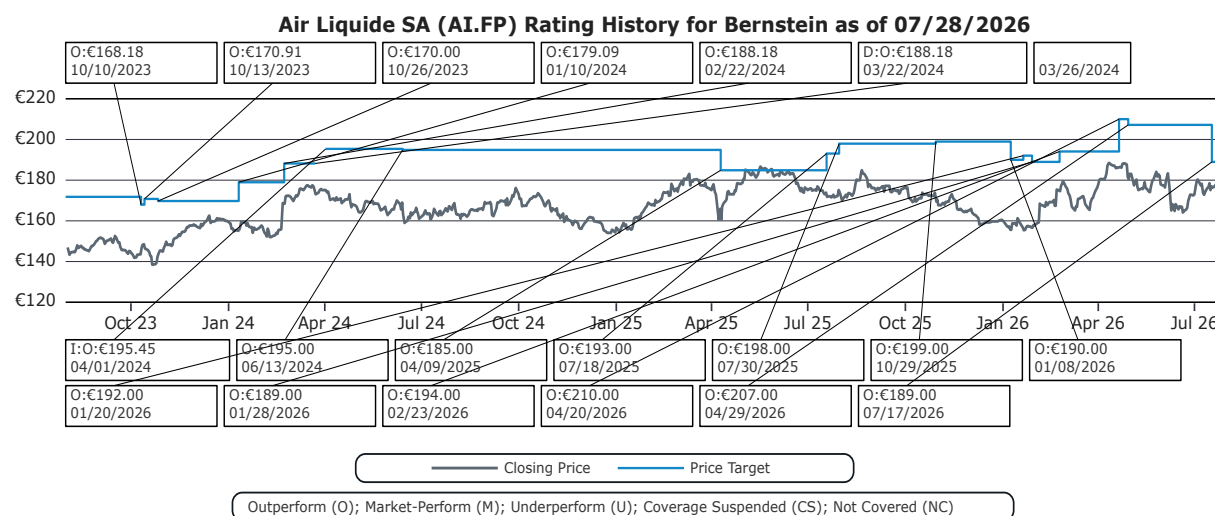
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Market-Perform (Bernstein Brand) Neutral (Autonomous Brand)	HOLD	35.8%	16.2%
Underperform	SELL	13.1%	13.6%

* These figures represent the percentage of companies within each equity rating category for which affiliates of Bernstein have provided investment banking services within the previous 12 months.

As of June 30, 2026. All figures are updated quarterly.

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